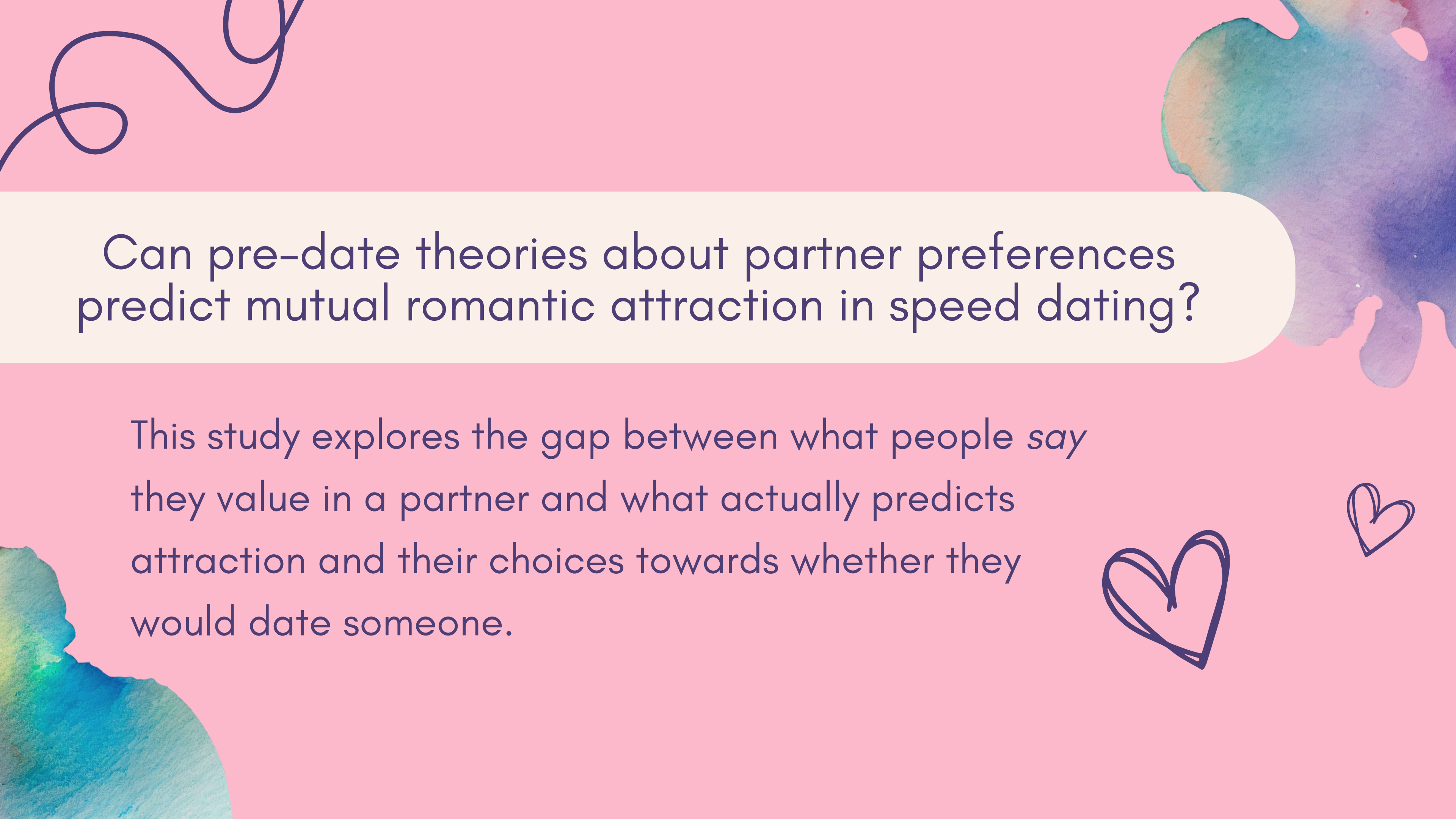




From Checklists to Chemistry, What Predicts a Match?

Cogs 105
Cecilia Kuang



Can pre-date theories about partner preferences predict mutual romantic attraction in speed dating?

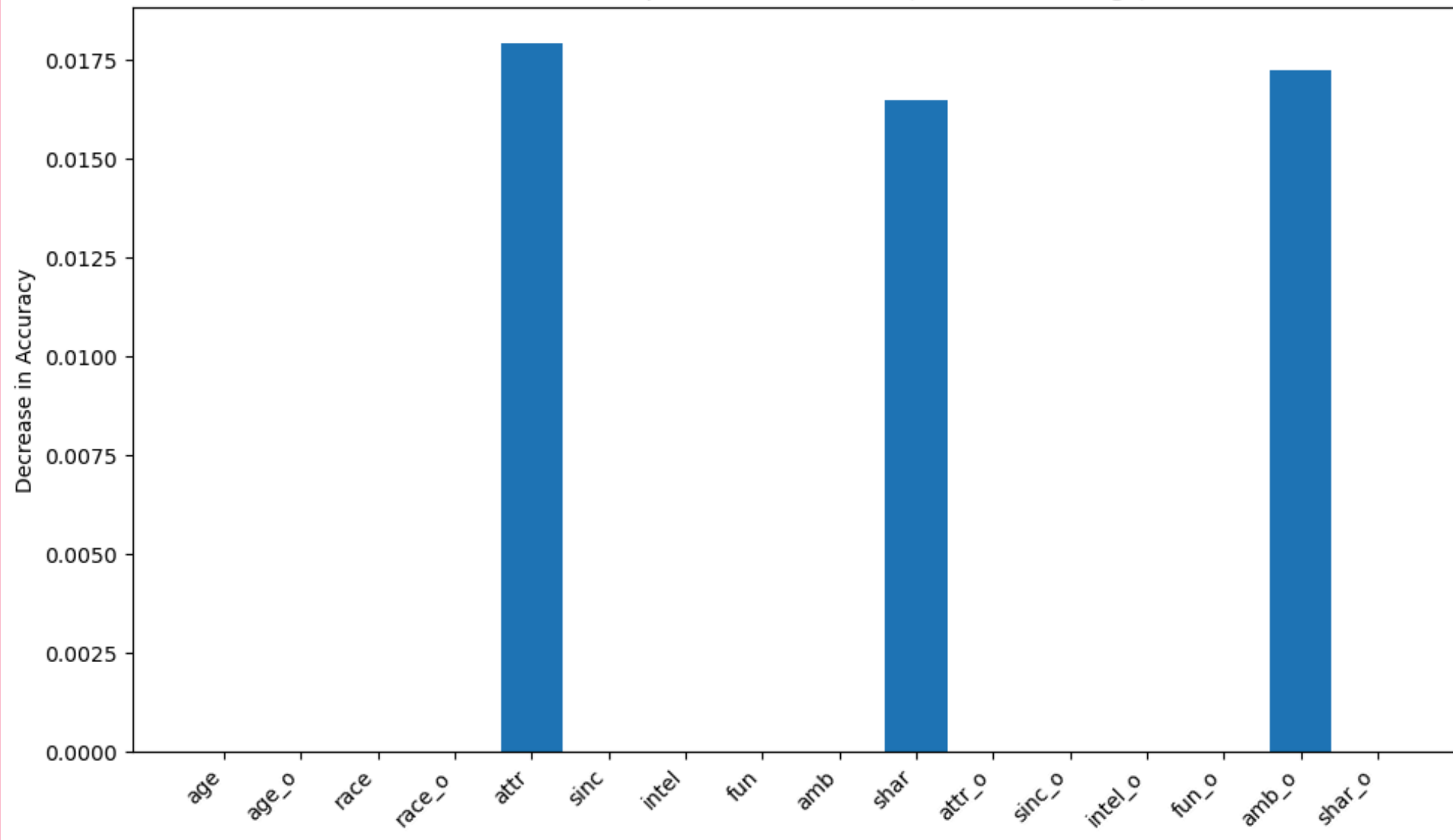
This study explores the gap between what people say they value in a partner and what actually predicts attraction and their choices towards whether they would date someone.



People often say they know what they want in a partner, but their match decisions are driven more by how a date actually feels than by what they thought mattered beforehand.



Permutation Importance — Model C (Post-Date Ratings)

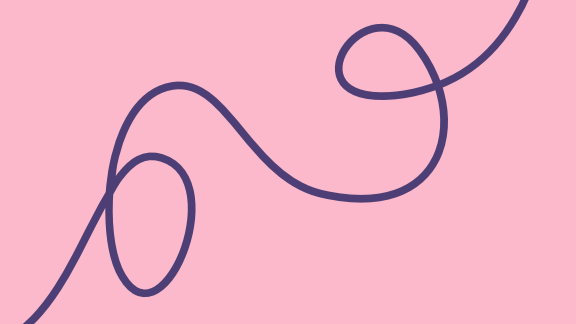


Pre-date theories $\neq$ actual dating behavior

Models using post-date ratings achieved higher predictive accuracy and ROC AUC than models using stated preferences alone. Most important predictors: attractiveness, shared interests, partner-perceived ambition

The results suggest that people's abstract beliefs about what they value in a partner do not fully align with the factors that influence their real-world dating decisions.





So what do we know now that we didn't know before?

People are not very accurate at predicting what will drive their romantic decisions.

While participants had clear theories about what they valued in a partner before dating, those stated preferences were weak predictors of actual matches. Instead, real-time impressions formed during the interaction—especially attractiveness, shared interests, and perceived ambition—were far more informative.

Our conscious dating preferences appear to function more as explanations than as accurate predictors of romantic choice. Real attraction emerges during interaction, not before it.

